

Dopamine is the chemical messenger in your brain that creates a good feeling when you do something enjoyable. It also impacts memory and motivation, making you want to repeat whatever got you that good feeling, which is why dopamine plays a role in addiction. Many things trigger dopamine release: your favorite activities, scrolling social media, sugar, sex, shopping, and, of course, certain drugs. Scientists now believe that dopamine's role isn't to directly cause good feelings, but to serve as a reinforcement for remembering and repeating pleasurable experiences. So, in the case of drug addiction, surges in dopamine don't stop at causing euphoria, they teach your brain, in unnaturally heightened amounts, to remember the experience. So, while anything that triggers dopamine release can be addictive, it's far easier to change dopamine-induced habits in things that don't elicit as much dopamine, like shopping. But just because it's doable doesn't mean it's easy.

Every time you check out at a store or hit the Buy Now button, dopamine is released and you have a pleasurable experience, but we know that experience doesn't last. So why do we keep pleasure shopping? Because dopamine is simultaneously teaching your brain to remember the pleasurable experience of every purchase, no matter how short-lived. And the more purchases you have, the more pleasurable experiences you have to draw from. It doesn't stop there, because every time you remember that pleasurable experience, more dopamine is released, further instilling in your brain that shopping = fun and happiness.

Even when we know an action is ultimately bad for us, dopamine inundates us with reminders of how sweet the instant gratification is. It's why we eat more than we want, scroll late into the night, and shop beyond what we can reasonably afford. It doesn't matter how many times someone tells us we need to save for retirement or that buying all this new stuff is contributing to 60 percent of all greenhouse gas emissions,² the instant gratification is all that matters.

Neuroscientist Robert Sapolsky trained monkeys³ to know that if they pressed a button ten times, after a signal lit up, then on the tenth button press, a food treat would appear. During each signal, work, reward cycle, Sapolsky measured the amount and timing of dopamine release in the monkeys' brains. You might predict that dopamine release would spike with the reward, but in reality the opposite was true. The dopamine release started as soon as the signal lit up, peaked up until the ninth press, and